Given this multiplicity, it is very difficult to generalize about the ethnic origins of all Indians. Nonetheless, twenty-first-century genetic studies provide some clues about how the Indian population came to resemble today's complex milieu. This too is an evolving area of study, but we are getting some sense of the broad contours.

The first thing that should be clear from the outset is that there are no 'pure' races. With the possible exception of some tiny isolated groups, the vast majority of Indian tribes, castes and communities are a mixture of many genetic streams. This merely confirms what we can all see—that Indians come in all shapes, sizes and shades—and these can vary quite a lot even within the same family. Nevertheless, some patterns of genetic distribution are discernible.

The first clue came with a 2006 study that India's population mix has been broadly stable for a very long time and that there has been no major injection of Central Asian genes for over 10,000 years [24] . This means that even if there had been a large-scale influx of so-called Indo-Europeans, it would have taken place more than 10,000 years ago, long before iron weapons and the domestication of the horse. Similarly, the study suggests that the population of Dravidian speakers has lived for a long time in southern India and the so-called Dravidian genetic pool may even have originated there.

More recent studies have added colour to these discoveries. A study led by David Reich of Harvard Medical School, published in *Nature* in 2009, suggests that the bulk of the Indian population can be explained by the mixture of two ancestral groups—the Ancestral South Indian (ASI) and the Ancestral North Indian (ANI). [25] The ASIs are the older group and are not related to Europeans, East Asians or any group outside the subcontinent. The ANIs are a somewhat more recent group and are related to Europeans.

Not surprisingly, Ancestral North Indian genes have a larger share in North India and account for over 70 per cent of the genes of Kashmiri Pandits and Sindhis. However, it is interesting that ANI genes have a large 40–50 per cent share even in South India and among tribal groups of central